WEEK 6 · LECTURE L1 · UNIT II

Engagement, Performance and Conversation Tools

What pulse apps, continuous performance tools, HR chatbots and mobile HR can do, where they over promise, and the theories that decide whether they help.

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AFTER THIS LECTURE YOU SHOULD BE ABLE TO

What this lecture prepares you for

1. Explain engagement with Kahn’s three conditions, the Job Demands Resources model and the UWES, and design a pulse that closes the loop.
2. Apply goal setting and feedback intervention theory to continuous performance tools.
3. Evaluate HR chatbots by resolution, not deflection, and apply mobile first design for a frontline workforce.
4. Judge where engagement, performance, chatbot and self service tools over promise, and where employee experience language becomes surveillance.

ONE SOURCE

The same theories as the in class lecture and the course hub, without the simulation data used in class. Course outcome: CLO 2.

COMMIT BEFORE THEORY

Commit to an answer first

A firm replaces its annual appraisal with an app that sends every employee a weekly score and their rank in the team. What does feedback research predict?

A

Performance will rise, because feedback is now frequent

B

Performance may fall for many, because ranked feedback draws attention to the self, not the task

C

No effect, because employees ignore apps

D

Performance will rise only for low performers

EXAM LENS

The answer is B (Kluger and DeNisi, 1996).

THEORY IN DEPTH · KAHN (1990)

People engage when work is meaningful, safe and possible

Meaningfulness

Is it worth bringing myself to this work?

Safety

Can I show myself without fear of damage to self image, status or career?

Availability

Do I have the physical, emotional and mental resources right now?

EXAM LENS

Engagement is bringing one’s physical, cognitive and emotional self into a work role. A pulse that asks only about satisfaction misses all three conditions; a pulse in which staff fear their answers will be traced fails safety before any question is read. Kahn’s work was qualitative, in two settings; later survey measures stretched the idea.

THEORY IN DEPTH · BAKKER AND DEMEROUTI (2007)

Demands drain; resources engage

Job demands

Workload, emotional strain, role conflict: they cost energy and lead through strain to burnout.

Job resources

Autonomy, feedback, support, development: they build energy and lead to engagement, and buffer demands. Personal resources and job crafting extend the model.

Measuring engagement (UWES)

Vigor (energy, resilience), dedication (significance, pride), absorption (engrossed). 17, 9 and 3 item versions; the short form suits frequent pulses (Schaufeli et al., 2002; 2006).

EXAM LENS

An app that adds logins and forms is a new demand; it must also add a resource, such as faster leave approval. Classify each feature as a demand or a resource. Critics argue the model is so broad almost anything fits.

RECENT EVIDENCE · BAKKER, DEMEROUTI AND SANZ-VERGEL (2023)

The originators' ten year update adds four innovations: a person by situation approach, multilevel JD R theory, proactive approaches, and the work and home resources model.

ENGAGEMENT TOOLS

An annual survey measures; a pulse must act

Annual survey

Long, once a year, results months later. Good for trends, poor for action.

Pulse survey

A few questions, weekly or monthly, on conditions and resources, with fast results.

Close the loop

1 Ask. 2 Act visibly on what results show. 3 Tell staff what changed because of what they said.

EXAM LENS

Frequency without action produces survey fatigue faster than the annual survey ever did. The tool is rarely the problem; the loop is.

THEORY IN DEPTH · LOCKE AND LATHAM (1990; 2002)

Specific, hard goals with feedback raise performance

The core idea

Specific, difficult goals produce higher performance than vague “do your best” goals, given commitment, ability and feedback.

How it works

Four mechanisms: goals direct attention, energize effort, increase persistence and prompt task strategies. Moderators: commitment, feedback, self efficacy and task complexity.

Limits and critique

For complex, new tasks, learning goals work better than tough performance targets.

IN PRACTICE

A goal tracking or OKR app helps only if goals are specific and feedback reaches the employee, not only the manager.

EXAM LENS

Name the moderators; answers that skip them are incomplete.

THEORY IN DEPTH · KLUGER AND DENISI (1996)

Feedback can make performance worse

The core idea

A meta analysis of 131 studies found that in about a third of cases feedback interventions lowered performance.

How it works

Feedback aimed at the self (ranks, comparisons, judgments of the person) diverts attention from the task; task focused feedback on what to do differently helps.

Limits and critique

Effects vary widely with how, when and by whom feedback is given.

IN PRACTICE

A leaderboard that ranks branches or stores may lower performance; specific feedback on the task is the safer design.

EXAM LENS

This is the key counter evidence to “more feedback is always better”.

RECENT EVIDENCE · WISNIEWSKI, ZIERER AND HATTIE (2020)

A meta analysis of 435 studies finds a medium average effect of feedback (d = 0.48) but wide variation by the information it carries: feedback is not one treatment. The studies are of students, not employees.

CONTINUOUS PERFORMANCE MANAGEMENT

From annual ratings to frequent conversations

	Annual appraisal	Continuous performance
Rhythm	Once a year	Regular check ins, real time feedback, snapshots at project end
Focus	Judging the past	Coaching the next step, separate from pay talk
Known problems	Ratings reflect the rater; recency bias, halo effects, politicized ratings; too late to change behavior	Needs managers able to hold good conversations
Example	Most large firms historically	Deloitte’s redesign (Buckingham and Goodall, 2015)

EXAM LENS

Roots: agile methods, evidence against ratings and forced ranking, learning theory on immediate feedback (Cappelli and Tavis, 2016). The tool schedules the conversation; only a capable manager makes it a good one. Evaluate the tool and the managers together.

RECENT EVIDENCE · PULAKOS, MUELLER-HANSON AND ARAD (2019)

Decades of effort to make ratings accurate gave way to experiments: dropping ratings, real time feedback, coaching and new forms of goal setting.

Deflection is not resolution

Two kinds of bot

Rule based: fixed decision trees, predictable, limited to the script. AI based: understand free text in several languages, but can answer wrongly with confidence.

The trap

Deflection counts queries handled without a human; resolution counts problems solved. A bot can deflect 60% and resolve far less.

The design rule

Measure resolution, and give every conversation an exit to a person.

Few fields, big targets

Every extra field loses users on a small screen and slow connection.

Work offline

Tolerate patchy data; save progress; sync later.

Their language, their channel

Vernacular text and voice, in channels people already use, such as WhatsApp.

Reach the unreachable

Feature phone users cannot use an app or bot: voice or SMS is their only route.

WHERE TOOLS OVER PROMISE

Five promises, and what often happens

The promise	What often happens
Pulse apps raise engagement	They deliver measurement; engagement changes only when someone acts on results
Continuous performance apps build a feedback culture	They deliver prompts; without capable managers, frequent check ins become box ticking
Chatbots cut helpdesk load	They deliver deflection; satisfaction falls when answers are wrong or no person can be reached
Mobile self service for everyone	Reach only for those with device, data and literacy
AI screening is objective	It reproduces the patterns in its training data

EXAM LENS

Tools are often bought for the employee who already has a laptop; the frontline majority bears the cost of the mismatch. Wellbeing apps are often among the least used: stigma and privacy fears deter use.

EMPLOYEE EXPERIENCE

Moments that matter, and a caution

Definition

The sum of what employees perceive across their journey, from recruitment to exit, with attention to moments that matter: first day, first payslip, a transfer, a grievance.

Why it needs several functions

HR, IT, facilities and line managers shape it together. A great app with a broken payroll process is a bad experience.

The caution

Experience language can make monitoring sound like care. The test: do employees gain control and voice, or only visibility to the employer?

EXAM LENS

Manuti and de Palma (2018, Chapters 4 and 5): in a social collaboration platform case, employees gained channels, agency and responsibility; the firm gained a shared identity.

Course framing; the filed Manuti and de Palma has no employee experience chapter.

APPLY

A pulse app nobody believes

Teaching case (Course framing)

A Coimbatore textile exporter with 6,000 workers launched a weekly pulse app and a weekly performance score with team ranks. Response fell from 70% to 15% in four months. Workers say nothing changes after they answer, and supervisors use the ranks to scold the bottom five every Monday.

Work it through

1. Which step of the pulse loop is broken?
2. Which of Kahn’s conditions is being damaged, and how?
3. What does Kluger and DeNisi predict about the weekly ranks?
4. What would you measure instead, using JD R?

COMMON CONFUSIONS

Tempting readings, and better ones

A tempting reading	A better reading
More frequent feedback always helps	About a third of feedback interventions lowered performance; focus on the task, not the self
Engagement is the same as satisfaction	Engagement rests on meaningfulness, safety and availability
A bot that deflects most queries is working	Deflection is not resolution; measure problems solved
A continuous performance app creates a feedback culture	Manager capability is the binding constraint

COMPARE AND EVALUATE

Six lenses on engagement and performance tools

Lens	Use it to	Watch out for
Kahn (1990)	Judge what a pulse measures	Qualitative origins
JD R (2007)	Classify features as demands or resources	Very broad
UWES	Measure vigor, dedication, absorption	Self report
Locke and Latham	Design goals	Complex tasks need learning goals
Kluger and DeNisi	Judge feedback design	Effects vary widely
Resolution, not deflection	Judge a chatbot	Resolution is harder to measure *

* Course framing.

PRACTICE FOR THE END TERM EXAMINATION

Questions to rehearse (1 of 2)

A Mumbai bank replaces annual appraisals with a continuous performance app and adds a weekly engagement pulse. Using goal setting theory, feedback intervention theory and the JD R model, evaluate the design and identify two risks. **20 marks**

A strong answer: applies Locke and Latham’s mechanisms and moderators; uses Kluger and DeNisi to judge the feedback; uses JD R and Kahn to judge the pulse; names risks such as ranked feedback, survey fatigue or weak manager capability.

“Engagement apps measure engagement but rarely create it.” Critically evaluate using Kahn (1990) and the JD R model. **20 marks**

A strong answer: distinguishes measurement from conditions; applies safety and availability; classifies features as demands or resources; addresses closing the loop.

PRACTICE FOR THE END TERM EXAMINATION

Questions to rehearse (2 of 2)

Evaluate the shift from annual appraisal to continuous performance management using goal setting and feedback intervention theory. **20 marks**

A strong answer: applies Locke and Latham with moderators; uses the one third finding; notes manager capability as the binding constraint.

Why is chatbot deflection a misleading success metric? **10 marks**

A strong answer: distinguishes deflection from resolution and proposes better measures, with a human exit.

CARRY THESE INTO THE EXAMINATION

Four things to remember

1. **A pulse works only when results are acted on and reported back.**
   Ask, act, tell.

2. **Feedback on the task helps; feedback on the self can hurt.**
   Rankings are risky.

3. **Measure chatbot resolution, never deflection alone.**
   Always offer a human exit.

4. **Design for the phone and the regional language first.**
   And for those with no smartphone at all.

SET READINGS · FROM THE LESSON PLAN

Read for this week

- Bondarouk, T., Parry, E., & Furtmueller, E. (2017), the adoption and consequences sections.
- Venkatesh, V., Morris, M. G., Davis, G. B., & Davis, F. D. (2003). *MIS Quarterly, 27*(3), 425 to 478.
- Manuti, A., & de Palma, P. D. (2018), Chapters 4 and 5.

NOTE

The other works named in this lecture are theory sources for reference, not set readings.

Sources for this lecture

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- Schaufeli, W. B., Bakker, A. B., & Salanova, M. (2006). The measurement of work engagement with a short questionnaire. *Educational and Psychological Measurement, 66*(4), 701 to 716.
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- Wisniewski, B., Zierer, K., & Hattie, J. (2020). The power of feedback revisited: A meta analysis of educational feedback research. *Frontiers in Psychology, 10*, 3087. https://doi.org/10.3389/fpsyg.2019.03087